

Chapter 139_1 - Infinite

"Do you like it?" Chu Qingqiu seemed uncertain.

"I love it to death." Ning Fuyi traced her fingertip across the uneven grooves, her face lighting up with joy, and couldn't help but lean forward to kiss Chu Qingqiu's cheek with a loud *mwah*.

Several soft chuckles could be heard, but when she turned around, the others were all looking up at the sky, praising the fireworks above with words of admiration.

"Look at that one, so beautiful," Jiuying said with a grin.

"Yes, yes indeed," Jiang Li agreed with a smile.

Chu Qingqiu secretly pinched Ning Fuyi, lowering her gaze with a serious expression, though her face was slightly red.

This night was the happiest night of Ning Fuyi's entire life. All her beloved ones were by her side, chatting and laughing warmly, drinking wine with flushed faces, while below the mountain the Fire Trees and Silver Flowers¹ bloomed, and above, bright lanterns sparkled brilliantly.

When the excitement reached its peak, the group of people and two birds sang songs arm in arm. Ning Fuyi didn't want to participate, so she pretended to be drunk and lay back among the flowers, gazing at the sky that flickered bright and dim.

The sound of firecrackers continued, and countless Kong Ming lanterns² carrying wishes floated up to the mountain.

Chu Qingqiu stood at the cliff's edge with her hands behind her back. With a turn of her palm, the brightest lantern fell into her hand. Written on it: "May my mother recover from illness and be healthy."

She lowered her head in contemplation for a long while, then gently raised her finger. A wisp of Flying Feather Rope-like light smoke entered the lantern's wick, and when she released it, the Kong Ming lantern drifted away again.

"I had thought these things sent to the sky were merely mortal delusions, but I never expected anyone would actually pay attention to them," another clear voice spoke from behind.

Chu Qingqiu didn't turn around, only smiled faintly: "The mortal world is bustling, and wishes are many. What I can see and help with my power is but a drop in the ocean compared to them all."

"The changes of worldly affairs all follow their own way, and mortals have little strength—it's indeed difficult to control," Jiang Li gazed toward the starry river below the mountain, lost in thought.

"Not just mortals—we are all the same," Chu Qingqiu murmured.

"Mortals pray for immortals' guidance in their vain desires, but what about immortals? Who can help them?" Jiang Li suddenly let out a soft laugh, filled with desolation.

Chu Qingqiu's fingertips trembled slightly, but she said nothing.

"What are the Divine Venerable's future plans? Will you live in seclusion on Purple Cloud Peak with Ning Fuyi?" Jiang Li changed the subject, speaking in a low voice.

Chu Qingqiu paused before saying, "I don't know."

"But this is what she wishes," she added. "Ning Fuyi is different from me. I cannot force her."

Jiang Li nodded.

"Divine Venerable, I've often been hating myself lately. Practicing medical arts was once my life's pursuit, but now I'm deeply trapped by it, unable to find liberation," Jiang Li said.

"Why?" Chu Qingqiu glanced at her.

"Because practicing medicine saves people, but it cannot kill people," Jiang Li's usually pleasant voice became low and mournful. "A physician can save people, but cannot save the world."

"Divine Venerable." Jiang Li looked at Chu Qingqiu, then hesitated and raised her wine pot. "Shall we drink together?"

"No," Chu Qingqiu replied.

Chu Qingqiu could hear the sorrow and probing in her words, and deeply understood her pain of hating Penglai Realm but being powerless due to practicing medical arts, yet didn't know how to respond.

Jiang Li smiled, tears flashing briefly in her eyes. She spun around like dancing and was pulled into the crowd by Jiuying. Chu Qingqiu watched her retreating figure without saying a word.

Ning Fuyi, lying among the flowers, heard their conversation clearly but also said nothing.

After a while, Ning Fuyi almost entered dreamland, but was soon awakened by the wind. When she raised her head again, that group of people had already passed out drunk at the table.

Jiuying was hugging Bai Lin while singing, Liu Wenzhu and Rong Jin were sprawled on the table, Jiang Li was completely intoxicated, and Han Ya and Xi Que had even transformed back to their original forms, lying paralyzed on the ground.

Chu Qingqiu was nowhere to be seen. She hurriedly got up and searched around, then ran toward the stone hall. She saw the great doors of the hall were closed, and a lonely figure sat in front of the hall, alone in the cold wind.

"Qiu Yi?" Ning Fuyi called out, looking into the hall. "Where is Chu Qingqiu?"

"Master drank some wine and seemed to be in a bad mood, so she went into the hall to rest," Qiu Yi said. Several wine jars were placed beside her as she gazed toward the distant singing.

Ning Fuyi wanted to check on Chu Qingqiu, but after hesitating for a moment, she didn't go in. Instead, she sat down beside Qiu Yi and asked, "What are you looking at?"

"Nothing in particular," Qiu Yi said.

The fact that she didn't answer with "none of your business" was already considerable progress, Ning Fuyi thought.

Under the flickering fireworks, through the misty smoke, a seductive woman in red robes spun around holding a bewildered Bai Lin, her skirt passionate and fiery red.

Ning Fuyi smiled and snatched the wine pot from Qiu Yi's side, pouring a mouthful into her own mouth.

Qiu Yi didn't stop her. She rested her chin on her hand for a long time, then suddenly said, "Will you always be good to Master?"

"Naturally," Ning Fuyi replied.

"Master is truly the best person in the world. People always say she's cold and unfeeling, but it was exactly this unfeeling person who clumsily raised me." Qiu Yi said.

She suddenly laughed: "When I first arrived, I still needed milk. The Divine Venerable couldn't find milk and was afraid I'd starve to death, so she bought several sheep from the mountain to feed me goat's milk."

"Guess what happened—she bought male ones." Qiu Yi laughed heartily.

Ning Fuyi laughed along with her. It was exactly something Chu Qingqiu would do.

"Later when I no longer needed milk, Master borrowed a fairy servant from Condensing Heaven Sect Master to take care of me. But Purple Cloud Peak was really too high and barren, and the fairy servant's cultivation wasn't high. She had to go down the mountain constantly to shop, and eventually got so tired that she cried and fled back to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate."

"After going through several fairy servants this way, Master finally lost face and started carrying me to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate every day to mooch meals. Her normally proud face was worn almost transparent during those years."

Ning Fuyi laughed even harder, imagining Chu Qingqiu with a stone-cold expression, holding a child while sitting in the dining hall.

This was a side of Chu Qingqiu she didn't know, so she pestered Qiu Yi to tell more stories. By the end, Qiu Yi's mouth was dry and she waved her hands, unwilling to continue, finally satisfying Ning Fuyi.

"Everyone has someone they want to protect in their heart. For me, that person is only Master. I feel that only I truly know Master's goodness, so anyone who treats Master badly, regardless of the reason, I consider an enemy."

"That's why I initially disliked you," she sighed, emboldened by the wine.

"I understand," Ning Fuyi said. If it were her former self, she would have retaliated against all hostility, but now, having experienced so much, she could step outside herself and view things with equanimity.

For some reason, she always felt that after dying once, Qiu Yi had been worn smooth of all her temperament, becoming like flowing water, yielding to any curve.

She was lost in thought when the light in front of her was suddenly blocked. Looking closely, Qiu Yi was sliding toward her, falling to her knees. Ning Fuyi was so startled that her drunkenness instantly cleared.

"What do you mean by this?" Ning Fuyi reached out to pull her up, but the other was as heavy as a Buddha statue, her knees seemingly rooted to the ground.

"I want to ask you to protect Master," the tall woman said with her back bent. "I used to always call you useless, but actually I'm the useless one. I can't protect anyone I want to protect. Even this life was given by Master, and now I'm just barely surviving."

Ning Fuyi didn't understand why she was suddenly acting this way. She stared at her for a while, then gave up trying to pull her up.

"She is precious to my heart, so naturally I won't be negligent," Ning Fuyi frowned. "Qiu Yi, what's wrong with you?"

"And those around you too," Qiu Yi said, opening her bright black and white eyes.

Ning Fuyi instinctively looked toward the distance, her gaze lingering on that red robe. The owner of the red robe was still carelessly happy.

Bai Lin's tail was already wagging so fast it was a blur, pawing to escape her embrace, but as soon as he broke free, he was caught again by Jiuying. In that instant, Ning Fuyi actually saw irritation on a tiger's face.

Ning Fuyi couldn't help but smile.

"Alright," Ning Fuyi said. As soon as she finished speaking, the woman in front of her collapsed onto the steps, clearly too drunk to remain conscious, and instantly fell asleep.

Ning Fuyi sighed, threw the wine pot aside, and got up to leave.

This night was both lively and absurd. After the fireworks died down, everyone was unconscious, leaving only scattered lanterns flickering bright and dim. Mortals looking toward Purple Cloud Peak that night saw it as if immortals were in drunken revelry, with bright lanterns hanging high.

For several days after that night, Ning Fuyi continued to savor the boundless fireworks of that evening. However, the days before her were equally joyful. For several consecutive days, she shared the same pillow and bed with Chu Qingqiu, spending time among flowers and under the moon, drunk and enchanted.

¹ Fire Trees and Silver Flowers (火树银花): A poetic expression referring to brilliant fireworks or festive lights that resemble trees of fire and flowers of silver

² Kong Ming lanterns (孔明灯): Traditional Chinese flying lanterns made of paper with a small fire source, used to carry wishes and prayers into the sky